

Coastal Areas



EUROPE'S JAGGED, IRREGULAR coastline provides many nesting places for seabirds. Millions come ashore in the summer to lay their eggs and raise their young. Although steep cliffs are dangerous for young birds, it is harder for predators to reach them.

There is also safety in numbers—many seabirds crowd together in huge, noisy colonies made up of thousands of birds. Different species, such as guillemots, kittiwakes, gannets, and fulmars, may nest together on the same cliff. Each nests at a different level, sharing the small amount of space available. Unlike land birds, seabirds do not need a large feeding area or territory on land to gather food for their chicks. They feed mainly out at sea so they can nest close together on land.



Large, powerful wings for gliding and soaring

Long, strong legs for running and webbed feet for swimming

Great black-backed gull
(*Larus marinus*)
Length: up to 2 ft 7 in (79 cm)

Great black-backed gull

This large gull is a fierce hunter, taking a wide variety of prey, from fish and seabirds to rabbits. In the summer breeding season, it attacks seabird colonies on the coast, gulping down a chick in a single mouthful.

At other times of year, it scavenges for scraps on trash piles inland and around fishing ports and beaches.



Little terns are graceful and agile in flight, sometimes hovering over the water.

Long, pointed wings beat quickly up and down.

Sharp, pointed bill for gripping fish

Little tern
(*Sternula albifrons*)
Length: 11 in (28 cm)

Little tern

Bustling colonies of little terns gather on sandy beaches in summer. Members of the colony may help each other dive-bomb enemies and drive them away. Young terns have to learn the best places to fish and how to dive headfirst into the water like their parents. Unfortunately, the number of these terns have decreased because of people disturbing them.

Common murre

The common murre, or guillemot, spends a lot of time far out at sea. To catch fish, it dives below the surface, beats its wings rapidly, and steers with its feet. It only comes to the coasts to breed, forming dense colonies on cliff ledges. The birds are usually packed so close together that they touch their neighbors.

The common murre lays a single egg on bare rock, without a nest, so one parent always has to stay and protect the egg and chick and keep them warm while the other goes off to sea to feed.



Common murre
(*Uria aalge*)
Length: 1 ft 5 in (43 cm)

Narrow, pointed bill for seizing fish

Streamlined shape helps the bird move fast through the water.

European storm-petrel

The European storm-petrel is the smallest European seabird. Fluttering above the water, it picks up small fish and plankton from the surface. This petrel will often follow ships to feed on the scraps thrown overboard and may shelter near ships during storms. It nests in colonies, mostly on isolated islands because it cannot defend itself easily.



Slim, hooked bill

As it feeds, the bird's legs dangle down so it looks as if it is "walking" on water.

European storm-petrel
(*Hydrobates pelagicus*)
Length: 7 in (18 cm)